

but you wouldn't mind a bigger laundry. In a few cases, you can sit down with the architect and the interior designer of the project to customise the apartment. Ask if this is an option.

The sale contract

Please, at this point, I beg you, pay a solicitor or a conveyancer to rake over the contract. A property purchase is likely to be your life's biggest financial play, so why cut corners?

If you decide to go with what's on offer in its entirety, it's all in the contract. This document is the surety for what you'll be walking into, from the time you sign the paperwork to when you pick up the keys. You should be able to recite this document as well as you can sing Daryl Braithwaite's 'The Horses' word-for-word after a few beers. If the display suite has a built-in Westinghouse dishwasher, check the contract. Developers can legally swap like-for-like fixtures or fittings. That doesn't mean that they can substitute a high-end European brand oven with a budget whitegood that fell off the back of a truck on the Hume Highway, but they can swap it for a brand of equal value and quality. In the contract there will be an 'inclusions' clause that allows for such an alteration.

I recommend keeping track of 'open for inspections', for renting or buying, of other apartments by the same developer, and doing a private-eye stroll-through. Be alert for cracks in the walls, whether fixtures and fittings are withstanding everyday wear and tear, and whether the building is well maintained and common areas are tidy. Source old advertising and compare the bricks-and-mortar result with what was in the brochure, allowing for slight differences.

Getting a loan for a new apartment

Banks have become nervous about the number of apartments popping up, and obtaining a mortgage for one is likely to be trickier now than it was a few years ago. Just because it is a sparkling new property, the bank won't necessarily see it as a good investment for them, so enquire early to ensure your intended loan provider isn't tightening lending for this type of home. If they are open to it, banks and other lenders can offer conditional loan approval for an off-the-plan apartment – a commitment in principle only, based on the developer's pricing of the home you wish to buy – but you